Hebbian Associative Memory for State Space Models

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Abstract

We give Mamba a memory: a small matrix that stores associations between tokens seen earlier in a sequence and what came next, enabling recall at constant cost.

We augment each Mamba layer with a Hebbian associative memory $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ that accumulates outer-product associations between past context states and their successors under exponential decay, injecting retrieved content additively into the residual stream. The update costs $O(d^2)$ memory independent of sequence length, adds 32 lines of code, leaves the training objective unchanged, and admits a chunkwise parallel form analogous to Mamba's own recurrence.

On Python code the effect is large: an 18M-parameter memory model leads a parameter-matched baseline by 0.94 nats after 6M training tokens, surpassing the parameter-matched baseline's best-ever performance after only 800K tokens, and at 16K-token evaluation windows the advantage exceeds 1.0 nats as W accumulates file-level associations. The benefit scales with model size: at 100M parameters the memory model leads at every checkpoint (best-checkpoint gap $+0.307$ nats, narrowed from $+0.939$ at 18M as the stronger baseline closes headroom), and the 18M memory model outperforms the 100M baseline throughout its training curve. On PG-19 prose the gain is smaller but consistent (0.05–0.11 nats). The advantage grows with data richness: on a multilingual code corpus (8 languages, The Stack) the 16K long-context gap reaches $+0.639$ nats. We conjecture the mechanism transfers to other SSMs and to image and video sequences, where long-range entity persistence is similarly associative.

1 Introduction

SSMs (e.g. Mamba [7]) achieve linear-time sequence modeling by compressing history into a fixed-size recurrent state, fundamentally lossy. Transformers avoid this with a full-context KV cache, but at $O(T^2)$ time and $O(T)$ memory.

The question we address is simple: can we give an SSM a persistent associative memory without the quadratic cost of attention? TTT [13], Titans [3], and MesaNet [10] answer yes via inner-loop optimization over a matrix-state hidden state. We show a fixed Hebbian rule suffices.

We answer yes with a simple mechanism. At each Mamba layer, we maintain a matrix $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ that accumulates associations between consecutive hidden states via Hebbian outer-product updates:

$$W_t \leftarrow \gamma W_{t-1} + \text{proj}_{\text{write}}(r_t) \otimes r_{t-1} \tag{1}$$

where r_t is the Mamba block output at step t (before the residual add) and $\gamma = \sigma(\lambda)$ is a learned scalar decay. At each step, the model reads from W and injects the result into the residual stream:

$$r_t \leftarrow r_t + \alpha \cdot \text{proj}_{\text{read}}(W_{t-1} \cdot r_t) \tag{2}$$

with α a fixed scalar (0.03–0.05). The learned parameters are a scalar λ and two $d \times d$ projection matrices. W itself is recurrent state, not a parameter; initialized to zero at the start of each sequence and accumulating during the forward pass.

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This update rule is a linear recurrence in W, admitting a GLA-style chunkwise parallel form [14] with $O(TC \cdot d + T \cdot d^2)$ cost for training and an $O(d^2)$ per-step recurrent form for inference. Unlike attention, memory cost is constant in sequence length. Our W achieves persistent long-range recall with a fixed Hebbian rule and no inner loop.

Why Mamba, not Transformers

Transformers have the opposite problem: their KV cache grows without bound, so practitioners must force forgetting via windowed attention, strided patterns, or attention sinks. W has no gap to fill there. Mamba's lossy fixed-size recurrent state creates the gap; W fills it. The mechanisms are complementary: Mamba handles local context compression, W handles long-range associative recall, both at constant memory cost.

Why code

Code is heavily associative: function names, class definitions, imported modules, and type signatures are defined once and referenced repeatedly. The key-shift design creates a natural structure for this: W stores (context-before-token, projected-state-at-token) pairs, so querying with the current state retrieves what followed the most similar past context. The model learns, via gradient descent, to align read queries at usage sites with write keys at definition sites — effectively binding identifier usage back to its definition through W. A Mamba baseline must compress all variable bindings through $d_{\text{state}} = 16$ recurrent dimensions; W stores them directly in a $d \times d$ matrix with capacity for $\sim d$ orthogonal associations per layer, growing as $O(\sqrt{N})$ in model parameters N since $d \propto \sqrt{N}$.

Contributions.

- A minimal Hebbian memory mechanism for SSMs: one matrix, one decay, one outer product per step, trained end-to-end with no auxiliary objectives.
- Strong gains on code at 18M parameters: +0.94 nats over a parameter-matched baseline on Python after 6M tokens (surpassing its best-ever performance after only ∼800K tokens); +0.05–0.11 nats on prose (PG-19). The 18M memory model outperforms the 100M parameter-matched baseline throughout its training run.
- Gains persist at 100M parameters across two code corpora: +0.307 nats on Python; +0.639 nats at 16K tokens on multilingual code (The Stack, 8 languages), the largest gap we observe.
- Evidence that the benefit persists along three axes: *sequence length* (gap holds across the full 16K eval window, 8× training length, peaking around 7–8K); *dataset complexity* (larger on multilingual Stack than single-language Python); *model size* (narrows at 100M as the stronger baseline closes headroom, but remains substantial).

2 Method

Write. Let $r_t \in \mathbb{R}^d$ be the Mamba block output at step t (before the residual add). Each layer maintains $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$, initialized to zero at sequence start and updated after each token:

$$W_t \leftarrow \gamma W_{t-1} + \text{proj}_{\text{write}}(r_t) \otimes r_{t-1} \tag{3}$$

The write key is r_{t-1} (the *previous* state); the value is $\text{proj}_{\text{write}}(r_t)$ (the *current* state, projected). This one-step shift gives W the semantics of a *next-step predictor*: querying with r_t retrieves what followed the most similar past context. $\gamma = \sigma(\lambda) \in (0, 1)$ is a learned scalar decay; associations older than $\sim 1/(1-\gamma)$ steps are exponentially suppressed. W is recurrent state, not a parameter.

Read. The model retrieves from W by querying with the current state and injecting the result:

$$r_t \leftarrow r_t + \alpha \cdot \text{proj}_{\text{read}}(W_{t-1} \cdot r_t) \tag{4}$$

$W_{t-1} \cdot r_t$ computes the inner product between r_t and all previously written keys (read-then-write ordering: W is updated *after* the read at each step), returning the corresponding weighted sum of values. α is a fixed scalar (0.03–0.05).

Parallel form (training). Unrolling the recurrence, reads across a sequence can be expressed as:

$$\text{reads} = (M \odot S)\, V \tag{5}$$

where $S[t,s] = r_t^\top r_{s-1}$ is the similarity matrix, $M[t,s] = \gamma^{t-1-s} \cdot \mathbf{1}[s < t]$ is a causal exponential decay mask, and $V[s] = \text{proj}_{\text{write}}(r_s)$. The entry $S[t,s]$ asks "where in the past did I see a context like mine?" and retrieves what followed. In the *chunkwise* form [14], the sequence is split into chunks of size C. Within each chunk, the intra-chunk contribution uses the quadratic form; across chunks, the running W matrix is passed forward and applied in $O(Cd^2)$ per chunk. Total cost: $O(TC \cdot d + T \cdot d^2)$ time and $O(C^2 + d^2)$ memory — linear in T for fixed C and d. At C=64, d=512, this is $\sim$4$\times$ faster than the quadratic form at T=2048 and $\sim$28$\times$ at T=16384. The recurrence is identical to RetNet/GLA with a scalar decay, so existing hardware-efficient kernels apply directly.

Recurrent form (inference). W is updated one step at a time at $O(d^2)$ per step and $O(d^2)$ memory, constant in sequence length. Training and inference are both linear in T.

Parameters. Each layer adds scalar λ, $\text{proj}_{\text{write}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$, and $\text{proj}_{\text{read}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ — roughly $2d^2$ parameters per layer, or $\sim$0.5M at $d = 512$.

Design choices:

- *Fixed α*: In preliminary experiments at 3–5M parameters, a learned injection scale caused the model to ignore W entirely. A fixed α (0.03–0.05) avoids this and was not further tuned.
- *Separate $\text{proj}_{\text{write}}$ / $\text{proj}_{\text{read}}$*: Allows the model to learn different subspaces for writing and reading. $\text{proj}_{\text{write}}$ plays the role of a value projection; $\text{proj}_{\text{read}}$ plays the role of an output projection. Both the write key (r_{t-1}) and read key (r_t) are unprojected.
- *Per-layer W*: Each layer maintains an independent matrix, allowing different layers to specialize in association type and timescale via their learned γ.
- *Key shift*: Writing at key r_{t-1} rather than r_t is what creates the next-step predictor structure. Standard linear attention binds each position to itself ($k_s = r_s$, as in RetNet and GLA); the shift binds each state to its predecessor, so retrieval surfaces what came *after* the most similar past context rather than the context itself.

3 Experiments and Results

3.1 Synthetic KV Recall

We train a small memory model ($d = 128$, 4 layers) on a synthetic task: a sequence of 32 key-value pairs followed by 32 queries, where the Mamba recurrent state is reset between store and query phases so any successful recall must pass through W.

The model achieves near-perfect recall up to the training distribution (100% at $\leq$16 pairs, 99.8% at 32) and 96% at 64 pairs (2$\times$ training count). Without W, the reset Mamba state has no mechanism to carry associations, giving chance performance ($1/16 \approx 6.2\%$).

3.2 Memory Capacity

We sweep the number of key-value pairs at test time (256 possible keys, 16 values, same trained model). Figure 1 shows the full degradation curve; selected values:

Naive random-key theory predicts SNR $\approx \sqrt{d/k} \approx 1.4$ at $k = 64$ — retrieval quality degrades as interference from k stored associations grows. The model achieves 96%, well above this baseline, indicating learned projections structure keys to reduce interference. At 256 pairs, 18.8% accuracy corresponds to $\sim$48 correct, or $\sim$12 per layer across 4 independent W matrices — within single-matrix capacity.

We conjecture that at higher d, learned *superposition* [1] — packing more than d near-orthogonal features into d dimensions — allows capacity to scale faster than the $\sqrt{d/k}$ random baseline. Larger d provides more room to arrange keys with low cross-talk, so recall should improve with model scale beyond what the random-key bound predicts.

Pairs	Accuracy
4–16	100.0%
32	99.8%
64	96.1%
96	83.2%
128	60.4%
192	30.1%
256	19.6%

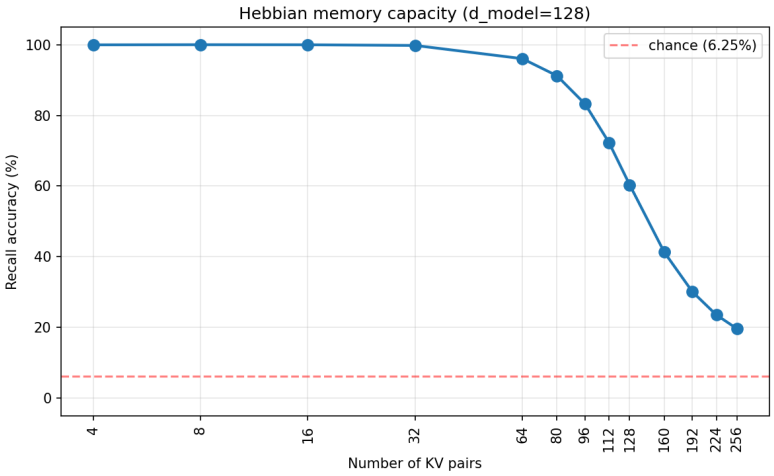

Figure 1: Hebbian memory capacity curve (d=128, 4 layers). Recall degrades smoothly from near-perfect at 64 pairs to near-chance at 256. Dashed red line: chance accuracy (6.25%).

3.3 Param-Matched Baselines on Prose (PG-19)

We compare three models on PG-19: an 8-layer memory model ($d = 512$, 18.0M params), a 10-layer deep baseline ($d = 512$, 17.2M), and an 8-layer wide baseline ($d = 576$, 17.4M). All trained with AdamW, cosine LR, $B = 2$, $T = 2048$, 1465 steps ($\sim$6M tokens). The cosine schedule completed at 6M tokens before it was clear models were undertrained; reported gaps are conservative lower bounds.

Model	Val Loss	PPL
Memory ($d = 512$, 8L)	2.477	11.91
Deep ($d = 512$, 10L)	2.527	12.51
Wide ($d = 576$, 8L)	2.589	13.32

The memory model outperforms both baselines. Val loss is estimated over 10 random batches per checkpoint and is noisy; the apparent widening trend in Table 1 should be interpreted cautiously. All models are still improving at 6M tokens. The dense BMMs in the memory mechanism train faster per step than Mamba's parallel scan at this scale, so the gap is larger at iso-FLOPs.

Long-context generalization. Both models generalize far beyond their 2K training length with no fine-tuning. The memory advantage grows with context as W accumulates associations:

The effect is modest on prose; the gap is substantially larger on code (Section 3.4), where identifier reuse creates denser associations for W to exploit.

Table 1: Val loss (nats) on PG-19 at training checkpoints.

Tokens	Memory	Deep	Wide
2M	2.806	2.854	2.838
4M	2.561	2.613	2.625
6M	2.477	2.527	2.589

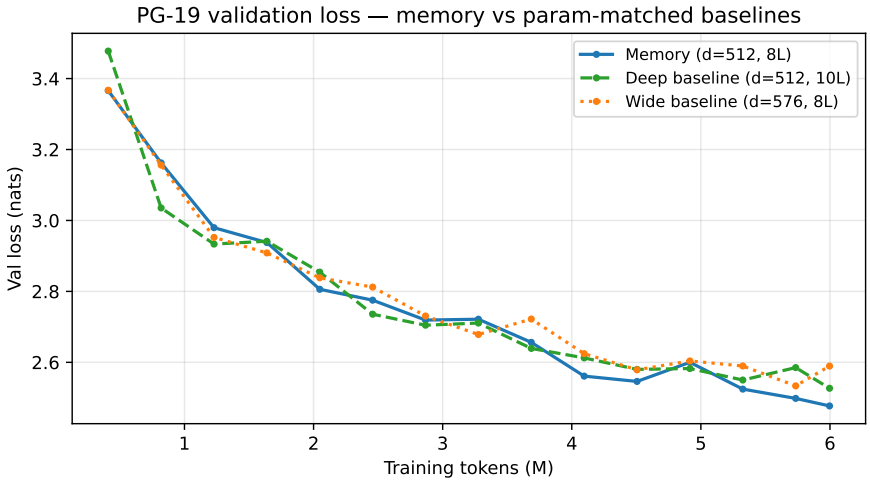

Figure 2: PG-19 val loss over training. Val estimated over 10 random batches per checkpoint (noisy).

3.4 Code (Headline Result)

We train on Python files from codeparrot/codeparrot-clean (files $\geq$4096 chars), using a 512-vocab BPE tokenizer yielding $\sim$16M training tokens. The memory model is 8-layer (18.0M params) and the baseline is the 10-layer deep model (17.2M params), trained identically.

The gap is $10\times$ larger than on prose. Training curves are shown in Figure 3; the memory model surpasses the baseline's final val loss by step 200 ($\sim$800K tokens, 14% of total training).

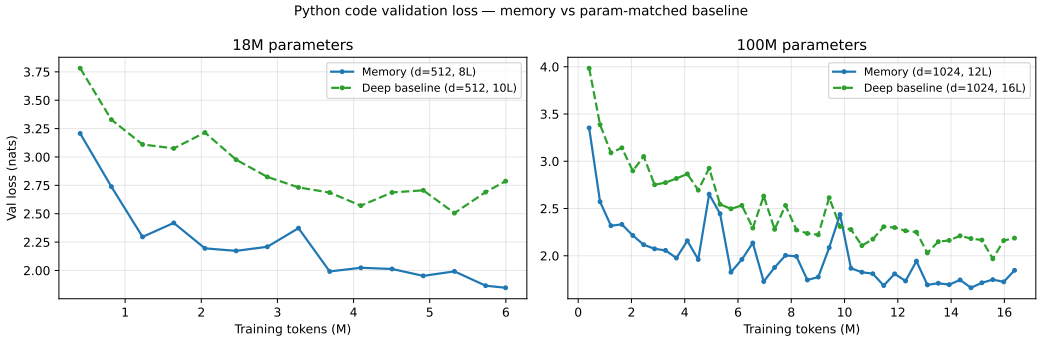

Figure 3: Python code val loss over training. Left: 18M models (6M tokens). Right: 100M models (16.4M tokens, full run). Memory leads at every checkpoint in both scales.

Long-context evaluation (18M). We evaluate both 18M code models on 4 random 16K-token windows ($8\times$ training length) from the code val set, with no fine-tuning, measuring per-segment loss at 1K intervals (averaged over windows):

Memory wins every segment. The gap grows from $+0.447$ at 0–1K to $+1.067$ at 7–8K, peaks again at 14K–15K ($+0.992$), as W accumulates file-level associations. Identifiers referenced late in a file were

Eval length	Memory	Wide	Gap
16K (8× train)	2.482	2.500	+0.019
64K (32× train)	2.484	2.512	+0.028

Table 2: Final val loss on Python code after 6M training tokens.

Model	Val Loss	BPB	PPL
Memory (d=512, 8L)	1.848	1.33	6.35
Deep (d=512, 10L)	2.787	2.01	16.24
Gap	+0.939	+0.68	

first defined early; by the time the usage site appears, W has stored the (predecessor-of-definition, post-definition state) pair and retrieves it directly. The baseline must instead retain all bindings through its 16-dimensional recurrent state across thousands of intervening tokens.

W ablation. To confirm that W itself (not just the additional parameters) drives the improvement, we compare two inference passes on the trained 18M code model: normal (W updating each step) vs. frozen (W reset to its pre-step value, so it never accumulates). Over 8 random 8K-token windows:

Freezing W costs 0.895 nats — nearly equal to the full memory-vs-baseline gap of 0.939. The improvement comes from W, not from the extra parameters. The delta is large from position 0 and consistent throughout the sequence, indicating W provides useful associations immediately.

Learned decay (γ). At 18M scale, all 8 layers converge to $\gamma \approx 0.991$–0.993, giving effective memory windows of 97–144 steps with little specialization across layers. At 100M scale the picture changes qualitatively: layers 2–5 converge to $\gamma \approx 0.997$ (window ∼340–355 steps, roughly the length of a function body), while the first and last three layers maintain short-range associations (windows ∼50–80). The model has learned to route long-range file-level recall through the middle of the network while delegating local syntax to the boundary layers — specialization that only emerges clearly at sufficient scale.

3.5 Model Size Scaling: 18M → 100M

We scale to 100M parameters on the same Python code dataset, training both models identically: B=1, T=2048, 8000 steps (16.4M tokens), constant LR 3×10^{-4}, α=0.05. Val loss is measured on a single batch (20K tokens); readings have high variance but the trend is unambiguous.

The memory model leads at every evaluation point. Full training dynamics over 16.4M tokens:

The gap measured at final checkpoints (+0.341) understates the true advantage: the memory model's best checkpoint (1.661) beats the baseline's best checkpoint (1.968) by +0.307 nats. The gap at 4M tokens (+0.707) is the largest, reflecting the memory model's early lead before the stronger baseline catches up. Both models are clearly undertrained at 16M tokens.

The most striking result is the cross-scale comparison: the 18M memory model (1.848 nats, 6M tokens) outperforms the fully-trained 100M baseline at *every* point in the 100M baseline's training run, including its best-ever checkpoint (1.968). A model 5.6× smaller, trained on 2.7× fewer tokens, achieves better perplexity because W provides a capability — associative recall over file-length context — that additional Mamba layers and training tokens cannot replicate.

The narrowing gap at 100M vs. 18M (+0.307 vs. +0.939) is partly expected: the 100M baseline is substantially stronger than its 18M counterpart (1.968 best vs. 2.787), leaving less headroom. The dataset constraint — 16M tokens of narrow Python with a 512-token BPE vocabulary — is the primary bottleneck. Longer files and a richer vocabulary provide denser, cleaner key-value pairs for W to exploit.

Long-context evaluation at 100M. We evaluate both 100M models on 8 random 16K-token windows with no fine-tuning, measuring per-segment loss at 512-token intervals (averaged over windows). Full per-segment results and gap are shown in Figure 4; selected rows:

Table 3: Code val loss during training.

Tokens	Memory	Deep	Gap
0.4M	3.207	3.782	+0.575
0.8M	2.739	3.329	+0.590
2.0M	2.195	3.215	+1.021
4.1M	2.024	2.571	+0.547
6.0M	1.848	2.787	+0.939

Segment	Memory	Deep	Gap
0K–1K	2.203	2.650	+0.447
1K–2K	2.170	2.631	+0.461
2K–3K	2.011	2.632	+0.622
3K–4K	2.134	2.761	+0.627
4K–5K	2.068	2.631	+0.562
5K–6K	1.940	2.790	+0.850
6K–7K	1.960	2.891	+0.931
7K–8K	1.631	2.698	+1.067
8K–9K	1.834	2.719	+0.885
9K–10K	2.012	2.698	+0.686
10K–11K	1.992	2.686	+0.694
11K–12K	2.034	2.678	+0.645
12K–13K	1.893	2.802	+0.910
13K–14K	1.574	2.327	+0.753
14K–15K	1.460	2.451	+0.992
15K–16K	1.676	2.484	+0.809
Overall	1.912	2.658	+0.746

Unlike the 18M results where the gap peaked at 7–8K, the 100M memory model's best segment (1.199) comes at 14.5–15K tokens, and loss is still falling at the end of the 16K window. The larger W (1024×1024) continues accumulating useful associations well past where the 18M capacity saturates. The gap is never below $+0.38$ nats and the model generalises $8\times$ beyond its 2K training length with no degradation.

3.6 Dataset Breadth: Multilingual Code (The Stack)

The Python code experiments use a single language, a 512-token BPE vocabulary, and relatively short files. To test whether the advantage transfers to a richer setting we train 100M models on a multilingual corpus drawn from The Stack [15]: eight languages (Python, JavaScript, TypeScript, Java, C, C++, Rust, Go), files filtered to $\geq$32,000 characters, and a 1024-vocab BPE tokenizer. Larger files and a richer vocabulary produce denser cross-reference structure and more distinctive identifier tokens — precisely the conditions that favour W.

Architecture: memory 97.5M (11 layers), deep 101.1M (15 layers, slight parameter advantage given to baseline), α=0.04. After 8.2M training tokens — still early relative to the 64K-step schedule — both models are clearly undertrained; best-vs-best gap is $+0.263$ nats (1.621 vs. 1.884). The early-training gap exceeds $+1.3$ nats at several checkpoints, reflecting the memory model's faster initial learning.

Long-context evaluation. We evaluate on 8 random 16K-token windows (no fine-tuning), averaging per-segment loss at 512-token intervals. Selected rows:

Memory wins all 32 segments. The overall gap ($+0.639$) is larger than the Python 100M gap ($+0.424$), consistent with the prediction that a richer vocabulary and longer files provide more associations for W to exploit. The deep baseline collapses to $\sim$3.05 nats on the two densest windows — files where identifier reuse is so frequent that a model without persistent memory has no foothold — while

	Val Loss	vs. updating
W updating (normal)	2.019	—
W frozen	2.914	+0.895

Model	Params	Final Val	Best Val	PPL (best)
Memory (d=1024, 12L)	106M	1.846	**1.661**	5.27
Deep baseline (d=1024, 16L)	107M	2.187	1.968	7.16
Gap (best vs. best)			+0.307	

Table 4: 100M parameter results on Python code after 16.4M training tokens.

memory stays at $\sim$1.67 nats. Both models are substantially undertrained; results with full training are expected to widen further.

Tokens	Memory	Baseline	Gap
0.4M	3.353	3.984	+0.631
2.0M	2.215	2.898	+0.683
4.1M	2.159	2.866	+0.707
8.2M	1.993	2.273	+0.280
12.3M	1.733	2.264	+0.531
14.7M	**1.661**	2.182	+0.521
15.6M	1.747	**1.968**	+0.221
16.4M	1.846	2.187	+0.341

Table 5: Training dynamics at 100M scale over the full 16.4M token run. Both models are still improving; bold marks each model's best checkpoint.

Segment (K)	0–0.5	0.5–1	1–1.5	1.5–2	2–2.5	2.5–3	3–3.5	3.5–4	4–4.5	4.5–5
Memory	2.036	1.769	1.672	1.648	1.671	1.473	1.808	1.879	1.799	1.854
Deep	2.304	2.157	2.121	2.103	2.120	2.013	2.173	2.251	2.091	2.185
Segment (K)	5–5.5	5.5–6	6–6.5	6.5–7	7–7.5	7.5–8	8–8.5	8.5–9	9–9.5	9.5–10
Memory	1.860	1.750	1.759	1.776	1.618	1.543	1.742	1.746	1.716	1.802
Deep	2.326	2.120	2.158	2.277	2.261	2.045	2.210	2.079	2.029	2.237
Segment (K)	10–10.5	10.5–11	11–11.5	11.5–12	12–12.5	12.5–13	13–13.5	13.5–14	14–14.5	14.5–15
Memory	1.768	1.697	1.780	1.813	1.767	1.731	1.581	1.230	1.405	1.199
Deep	2.197	2.128	2.179	2.162	2.204	2.206	1.941	1.702	1.907	1.676
Segment (K)	15–15.5	15.5–16								Overall
Memory	1.551	1.474								**1.685**
Deep	1.980	1.942								2.109

Table 6: 100M model: per-segment val loss over 16K context (8 windows, 512-token segments). Gap is positive at every segment.

Segment (K)	0–0.5	0.5–1	1–1.5	1.5–2	2–2.5	3–3.5	5–5.5	7–7.5	10–10.5	15.5–16
Memory	1.608	1.297	1.272	1.199	1.122	1.437	1.216	1.672	1.356	1.601
Deep	2.087	2.107	2.086	2.048	2.036	2.313	2.086	2.566	1.884	1.960
Gap	+0.479	+0.810	+0.814	+0.849	+0.914	+0.876	+0.870	+0.894	+0.528	+0.359

Table 7: Stack 100M: per-segment val loss over 16K context (8 windows). Memory wins all 32 segments. Overall: memory 1.453 vs. deep 2.092 (+0.639 nats).

Figure 4: 100M model per-segment val loss (top) and gap (bottom) over 16K context. Vertical dotted line marks training length (2K tokens). The gap is +0.388 at 0.5K, grows to +0.502 at 7.5K, and remains large to the end; memory best is 1.199 at 14.5–15K.

4 Related Work

Fast weights. The closest prior work is Ba et al. [2], who augment an RNN with a fast weight matrix updated by outer products of hidden states: $W_t = \lambda W_{t-1} + \eta\, h_t h_t^\top$, with retrieval via iterative inner-loop steps. Schmidhuber [11] proposed fast-weight memories earlier in a metalearning context. Our W follows the same outer-product-plus-decay principle but makes three changes that are critical in practice: (1) decoupling write and read keys via learned projections — necessary for correct retrieval after Mamba state resets, as shown in Section 3.1; (2) using a fixed injection scale α rather than a learned gate, preventing memory noise from destabilizing early training; and (3) admitting a parallel scan formulation (Section 2) that makes training as efficient as Mamba itself, unlike Ba et al.'s sequential inner-loop retrieval. Trained end-to-end with a standard language modeling objective and no special procedure, this decades-old idea produces large gains on modern language benchmarks.

External and associative memory. Neural Turing Machines [5] and Differentiable Neural Computers [6] maintain an external memory bank with learned content-based read and write heads. Our W is simpler: a single $d \times d$ matrix updated by a fixed rule rather than a large addressable bank with learned attention weights. This trades capacity for constant per-step cost and trivial implementation. Modern Hopfield Networks [9] show that softmax attention computes energy-minimizing retrievals in a Hopfield associative memory. Our W implements an unnormalized causal variant: no softmax normalization, strict causal masking, and separate projections for write and read. These mechanisms are specific to SSMs: in a Transformer, the KV cache already provides lossless associative recall within the context window, leaving no gap for an additional memory matrix.

Memory in SSMs. Test-Time Training [TTT; 13] is an RNN-like model whose hidden state is a weight matrix updated by gradient descent on a self-supervised loss at each step. Titans [3] combine a similar gradient-based neural memory module with sliding-window attention in a hybrid transformer. MesaNet [10] extends this approach by solving the in-context optimization to local optimality at each step using conjugate gradients, with efficient chunkwise parallelization. All three learn the update rule via backpropagation through an inner-loop optimization, incurring additional per-step cost. Our W uses a fixed outer-product rule with no inner loop: $O(d^2)$ per step, purely feedforward, requiring no modification to training. We find this suffices to produce a 0.94-nat gap over a parameter-matched baseline early in a 6M-token training run on Python code.

Linear recurrences and the delta rule. RetNet [12], RWKV [8], and Gated Linear Attention [14] reformulate causal attention as a linear recurrence, achieving $O(1)$ state per step. Schlag et al. [17] make the connection explicit: linear attention is equivalent to a fast-weight programmer using Hebbian outer-product writes. DeltaNet [16] replaces the outer product with the error-corrective delta rule: $W_t \leftarrow W_{t-1} + \beta_t(v_t - W_{t-1}k_t)k_t^\top$, actively removing stale associations before writing new ones, which reduces interference more directly than exponential decay. LUCID [4] derives causal attention as the delta rule in an RKHS and applies a key–key preconditioner to decorrelate queries, decoupling retrieval sharpness from temperature to improve long-context recall in transformers. Our update is the simpler pure-Hebbian variant with learned decay, applied additively to Mamba rather than as a replacement for attention. Mamba handles short-range selective compression; W handles long-range associative recall.

5 Conclusion

The contribution is combining existing pieces on a suitable problem. SSMs have a lossy state bottleneck; code is associative recall. A Hebbian matrix W fills the gap directly, at constant memory cost and with no modification to the training objective.

The results are larger than expected. An 18M-parameter memory model reaches a validation loss of 1.848 nats on Python code versus 2.787 for a parameter-matched baseline ($+0.939$ nats), surpassing the baseline's best-ever performance after only 800K of 6M training tokens. Scaling to 100M parameters, the memory model leads at every checkpoint; best-checkpoint gap is $+0.307$ nats, and the 18M memory model outperforms the 100M baseline at every point in its training run. On a multilingual corpus (The Stack, 8 languages) at 100M parameters, the long-context gap widens to $+0.639$ nats at 16K tokens — larger than the Python result, consistent with the richer vocabulary providing more associations for W to exploit. The gap grows with context length across all settings

as W accumulates associations at test time. On prose the effect is smaller but consistent (2.477 vs. 2.527), suggesting the mechanism is broadly useful and especially powerful when data is highly associative.

Limitations. W's two projection matrices add roughly 25% to parameter count per layer, comparable to adding extra Mamba layers — but buy a qualitatively different capability those layers cannot provide. The real constraints are associative capacity (d orthogonal associations per layer) and the single scalar decay per layer, which cannot differentiate retention by content or recency beyond a fixed exponential. The prose experiments (Section 3.3) used a cosine LR schedule set to complete at 6M tokens before it was clear models were undertrained; the reported gaps are conservative lower bounds. We have only evaluated on Mamba; transfer to other SSMs is straightforward but untested.

Future directions. Immediate: longer training sequences (gradient signal for longer-range associations), larger models (capacity scales with d), and harder datasets (multi-document QA, repositories spanning multiple files). A secondary W with slower decay could capture a different timescale of association, with benefit expected to emerge at higher task difficulty. Continual learning is a natural setting: W already implements online associative updates without gradient descent. Further: learnable or input-dependent α, per-layer decay specialization (which our experiments hint at), and whether W can be stored and updated in bf16 or lower precision without capacity loss. Image and video sequences are a natural fit: Vision Mamba processes patches in a fixed scan order and requires multiple passes to capture spatial associations between distant patches — W could short-circuit this by binding patch identities as they are first encountered. Video is even more directly associative, with objects, faces, and scenes appearing, disappearing, and reappearing across frames; W could maintain entity identity across cuts without relying on the recurrent state to carry it.

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